

Making Friends in Korea as a Foreign Student

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Finding Community at KNU

When I first stepped off the plane in 2024, the air in Korea felt different—not just because of the humidity or the scent of the city, but because of the weight of the unknown. As a foreign student, the initial "honeymoon phase" of moving to a new country is often quickly shadowed by the daunting reality of cultural and linguistic barriers. I remember standing in the middle of the KNU campus, surrounded by the bustling energy of students rushing to class, feeling like a silent observer rather than a participant. The challenge of making friends in a foreign land is a universal struggle, yet it feels deeply personal when you are the one trying to navigate a new social landscape. However, my journey at KNU taught me that while the "Daegu cold" might be a weather phenomenon, the hearts of the students here are anything but. By stepping out of my comfort zone and into the various communities offered by the university, I transformed my solitary experience into a vibrant, multicultural life.

In the beginning, my biggest obstacle was the fear of being misunderstood. Language is more than just words; it is the bridge to shared humor, empathy, and connection. Like many international students, I found myself sticking to the safety of my own room or only interacting with people from my own background. This isolation, while comfortable, was stifling my growth. I realized that if I wanted to truly experience Korea, I had to find "middle grounds"—spaces where the desire for connection out

weighed the fear of making a linguistic mistake. KNU is unique in that it offers specialized niches for these interactions, particularly through language-focused communities and programs led by the Office of International Affairs (OIA).

While I personally didn't speak German or French, I quickly noticed that for many of my peers, the department-led language exchange programs were vital social arteries on campus. For those with a specific interest in European cultures, programs like **Tandem** and **Midipause** provide a structured yet social way to bridge the gap between locals and internationals.

Tandem is a brilliant initiative where KNU students studying German are paired with German exchange students. What makes Tandem special is its reciprocity; it functions less like a classroom exercise and more like a social contract. One student helps navigate the nuances of Korean life, while the other offers a window into European culture. Similarly, **Midipause** provides a dedicated space for French major students and French-speaking internationals to engage in organic cultural exchange. Seeing these communities thrive made me realize that KNU has a specialized niche for everyone—you just have to look for the one that fits your interests. Even as an observer, witnessing the shared vulnerability of students nervous to speak a new language helped me realize I wasn't alone in my anxiety.

My most significant turning point came when I joined the **International Writing Center (IWC)**, but not just as a participant. I had the privilege of serving as an **English Mentor**. Organized by the OIA, the IWC is perhaps one of the most inclusive environments on campus. Its primary goal is to connect outgoing Korean exchange students with incoming international students to build practical skills, cultural understanding, and confidence for studying abroad.

What sets the IWC apart is its accessibility. It isn't just for students preparing to go abroad; it is open to any KNU student—Korean or international—who simply wants to practice English in a relaxed setting. Because the mentors are all students ourselves

s, the "pressure cook" environment of a traditional classroom disappears. As a mentor, I saw firsthand the hesitation in students' eyes when they first tried to speak. However, because the program is student-led and absolutely free, that hesitation quickly turned into laughter. I wasn't just "teaching" English; I was having deep, meaningful conversations about our lives, our dreams, and our shared struggles as students. Through these interactions, I realized that I wasn't just a guest at KNU; I was a contributor. Helping my Korean peers overcome their fear of English helped me overcome my own fear of not belonging.

Building on the foundation of the IWC, the OIA also offers the **Global Gateway Mentorship Program**, which I found to be a masterclass in social integration. This program specifically targets the "friendship gap" that exchange students often feel. Coming to a new country can be incredibly lonely, and even the most outgoing exchange students often find it difficult to break into Korean social circles.

The Global Gateway program solves this by connecting one exchange student with four Korean students who are genuinely eager to make foreign friends. This 1-to-4 ratio is a stroke of genius; it ensures the international student is immediately welcomed into a pre-existing "friend group." For the Korean students, it's a chance to experience a new culture without leaving Daegu; for the international student, it provides a vital support system that makes Korea feel like home. These programs prove that the desire for friendship is a two-way street; there are countless Korean students looking for us just as much as we are looking for them.

My perspective is also shaped by my unique academic path. As a student in the 2+2 double degree program between Christ University in India and KNU, I have spent the last few years bridging two very different worlds. This program is more than just an academic exchange; it is a life-altering experience that requires a high level of adaptability. In my final year of Computer Science, I've realized that the technical skills I've learned in the lab are only half of the equation. The other half is the "soft pow

er" of cultural empathy—the ability to connect with a classmate from Daegu or an exchange student from Paris. These social programs provided the framework I needed to balance my rigorous academic life with a fulfilling social one.

Looking back at the person who arrived in 2024, I barely recognize that version of myself. The silence of my early days has been replaced by the laughter of friends from both Korea and across the globe. Finding a community at KNU does not happen by accident; it happens by intention. Whether it is through the linguistic bridge of Tandem and Midipause, the collaborative spirit of the IWC, or the structured warmth of the Global Gateway Mentorship, the opportunities to connect are everywhere.

To any foreign student reading this who feels overwhelmed: take that first step. Join a workshop, sign up for a mentor, or simply say hello in the language lounge. KNU is more than just a university; it is a global village, and your place in it is already waiting.

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